

CONTRAST

Showing two very different things side by side



1 What is it?

Contrast (KON-trast)

Contrast places **two very different things, ideas or images** next to each other so their differences stand out more clearly to the reader.

thing A vs thing B (opposites)

2 See it in action

Light and dark

The city was bright with neon lights, yet the alley behind it stayed pitch black.

Rich and poor

His mansion sat just streets away from families sleeping in doorways.

Character contrast

She was calm and quiet; her brother was loud and reckless.

Mood shift

The wedding was full of laughter — until the doors burst open.



You got this!

Look for two ideas that feel like **opposites** — light/dark, rich/poor, calm/chaotic — sitting somewhere in the same text.

FUN FACT

Contrast is a favourite technique in film posters too — a peaceful character standing in front of a burning city is a visual version of exactly the same trick writers use with words.

3 Why writers use it

Contrast helps writers: highlight differences, create tension or drama, make a point more powerful by showing its opposite, and help the reader understand a theme (like inequality) by seeing it in action.

Contrast works because our brains naturally notice differences — putting something next to its opposite makes both things sharper and more memorable.

4 Don't mix it up!

Contrast

- Ideas can appear **anywhere** in a text
- Highlights a **difference** over time or theme
- "Rich vs poor" across a whole story

Juxtaposition

- Ideas placed **right next to** each other
- Same sentence/moment for **shock**
- "A funeral... at a birthday party"



Watch out!

Contrast and juxtaposition are closely related, and some exam boards use the terms loosely — but juxtaposition specifically means placing the two opposite things immediately side-by-side for effect.



Good spot!

Always ask **why** the writer chose that specific contrast — what point about the world or the characters is it making?

5 Quick recap

Two very different things

Placed side by side

Makes differences stand out



Keep going!

Try describing one place using two totally contrasting images — a street that is "warm with laughter" but "cold with silence" just around the corner.